

World Cup quarterfinal clash against Paris Saint-Germain following a collision with goalkeeper Gianluigi Donnarumma. The team must also cope without Alphonso Davies, who suffered a severe knee ligament injury while on national duty in March.

"Jamal still has crutches, but the process is very, very positive. So far, there have been no complications with either of them. We need to knock on wood so that it stays that way, and then obviously hope they will be available by the end of this year," said Bayern board member for sport Max Eberl when asked about a possible timeline for their return.

Leverkusen has a lot of changes to navigate this new season. Former Manchester United and Ajax manager Erik ten Hag takes charge of the Black and Reds and, like Leverkusen, will have a point to prove — especially after the circumstances of his departure from United. Ten Hag's biggest challenge will be coping without several star players, as the club has seen an exodus of key names. Wirtz, Jeremie Frimpong, Granit Xhaka and Jonathan Tah — all crucial to the club's dominance — have left, leaving massive gaps in the squad.

To fill them, it has kept itself busy in the transfer market, bringing in centre-back Jarell Quansah from Liverpool and midfielder Malik Tillman from RB Leipzig.

Borussia Dortmund, always expected by its passionate fanbase to challenge for the title, have often fallen short. Jude Bellingham followed in his brother Jude's footsteps by signing with the Ruhr club this summer, but a serious title push still looks unlikely for the Black and Yellows.

A new-look Italian top flight

In recent years, fans in Italy have grown used to the dominance of Juventus and, before that, the Milan giants — Inter and AC. But over the past few seasons, Napoli, historically looked down upon by the Italian elite, has made waves in Serie A, bringing back the glory years of Diego Maradona.



In the 2022–23 season, Napoli clinched the Serie A title for the first time since 1989–90 — its third overall — and got a fourth Scudetto last season after a neck-and-neck title battle with Inter, which saw Antonio Conte's men win the league by just one point. Needless to say, Inter will be hungry for revenge. Managed by Cristian Chivu, it will face a strong challenge from Napoli, which is

Legend on the move: Real Madrid won't enjoy the services of its midfield talisman Luka Modric, who has moved to AC Milan. GETTY IMAGES

bolstered by the exciting midfield duo of Kevin De Bruyne — who joined from Manchester City on a free transfer — and Scott McTominay, reborn since his move



Big brother shows the way: Jude Bellingham followed in his brother Jude's footsteps by signing with Borussia Dortmund. GETTY IMAGES